

a specific financial operation and available to any user who seeks that type of service, for example, to execute a put option, regardless of the size of the transaction. A user can largely self-serve within the parameters of the smart contract and of the blockchain the application lives on. In the case of Ethereum-based DeFi, the contracts can be used by anyone who pays the flat gas fee, currently around \$3 for a transfer and \$12 for a dApp feature such as leveraging against collateral. Once deployed, these contracts continually provide their service with near-zero organizational overhead.

### **Keepers**

Introduced in Chapter 4, keepers are external participants directly incentivized to provide a service to DeFi protocols, such as monitoring positions to safeguard that they are sufficiently collateralized or triggering state updates for various functions. To ensure that a dApp's benefits and services are optimally priced, keeper rewards are often structured as an auction. Pure, open competition provides value to DeFi platforms by guaranteeing users pay the market price for the services they need.

### **Forking**

Another concept that also incentivizes efficiency is a *fork*. In the context of open-source code, this occurs when the code is copied and reused with upgrades or enhancements layered on top. A common fork in blockchain protocols is